

What can religion contribute to the AI debate?

By Harris Bor, Ellen Broad, Barrister, Twenty Essex and Research Fellow, London School of Jewish Studies

In this module, Bor considers the relationship between religion and AI, and religion's possible contribution to the ethical AI debate. Using Judaism as a test case, Bor points to 7 core values that encapsulate key aspects of humanity. These values are: (1) Sanctity of the individual; (2) Virtue as foundation for knowledge; (3) Oneness and individuality; (4) Possibility of transformation; (5) Power of emotion; (6) Embodiment; and (7) Sacred time and space. By applying these values to questions around different innovations, Bor makes the case that religion can offer critical insights into how we develop and employ AI technologies in an ethical and responsible manner.

Lecture Transcript

0:02 Hello, my name is Harris Bor. I'm a UK barrister specializing in commercial litigation and international arbitration, a research fellow and lecturer at the London School of Jewish Studies in the areas of Jewish intellectual history and thought, and advisor to the US think tank, AI and Faith, and a trainee rabbi. I'm also author of the book, *Staying Human: a Jewish Theology for the Age of Artificial Intelligence*, which looks at the idea of the singularity and super intelligence through Jewish and philosophical lenses. Today, I would like to address the question, What can religion bring to the AI debate? I'm going to focus on Judaism, which is my own tradition, but many of the same values are found within other religions and ways of living.

0:52 I consider the topic to be important because AI raises so many questions which go far beyond AI itself, and which are similar to those asked by religion. Let me demonstrate this by looking at the nature of AI, its influences on our lives, and its ambitions. Starting with the nature of AI, the so-called Standard Model of AI, which dates back to the 1950s, describes human and machine learning like this. Humans are intelligent, to the extent that our actions can be expected to achieve our objectives. And machines are intelligent, to the extent that their actions can be expected to achieve their objectives. Now, these formulations raise many questions. For example, are we really intelligent only to the extent that our actions can be expected to achieve our objectives? What about emotional intelligence, intuitive intelligence, the intelligence we gain from messing up and failing to reach our objectives? Also, if AI is about our objectives, what are our objectives? These sometimes conflict as well, and they're shaped by our values. But what are our values? Now, religion has been central to developing those values and continues to play a profound role in giving meaning to people's lives, so it ought to have something to say to these questions. Moving to the influence of AI on our lives, we're already incredibly reliant on AI. But how are we going to feel when AI takes our jobs, and then our hobbies? And if AI does eventually make us immortal, which it promises to do, what are we going to do for the rest of eternity? Netflix is just not going to be able to keep up. And this gives rise to some more fundamental questions. If we can be replicated, what makes us unique? If machines outsmart us, what is our role in the world? Religion has grappled with these issues for many, many years, and therefore again, ought to have something to say to us.

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3:08 We then arrive at AI's ambitions. The main focus of my book, and for me, one of the most interesting ideas about the future, is the idea of the singularity, a term dating from the 1950s again, to describe the moment that computers will overtake humans, and we head into the unknown. For Ray Kurzweil, a winner of the 1999 US National Medal of Technology and Innovation, the singularity is only decades away. He says that after it's reached, there will be a quote, no distinction between human and machine or between physical and virtual. Instead, he says, intelligence will saturate the physical universe and reorganize matter and energy to provide an optimal level of computation. It will then spread out from its origin on Earth to turn the universe into a vast super intelligence. Now, this is a strange but not uncommon fantasy. The singularity features, in my opinion terrible, 2014 science fiction film *Transcendence*, featuring Johnny Depp, who plays Dr. Will Caster, a leading AI researcher working on the singularity, who was shot by an AI vigilante uploaded to a computer and here he is being uploaded, and attempts to take over the world. It features two in Yuval Harari's book, *Homo Deus*, in which he describes 'dataism' - a new religion for which data is everything. And humans will become what he says or calls the mere tools for creating the internet of all things, which may eventually spread out from planet Earth to cover the whole galaxy and even the whole universe. The sounds that have a bit by Kurzweil.

4:54 Harare writes that the first commandment of this new religion is to maximize data flow. And the second commandment is to connect everything to the system. And so what we have here is a secularized version of God, in which the all is effectively a machine, of which we are all a part. I use the term singularity here to capture this unity, the singularity is all intelligent, also as God, the singularity is all powerful. Well, so is Go. We are all connected to the singularity. Well, we're all connected to God. So we could see the similarities between the concept of the singularity and the idea of God. And what I find interesting is not so much whether this vision of the singularity accurately portrays the future. But what it says about our desires for oneness. We seem to hanker after some totality, and ultimate connectedness. It also highlights for me those features of religion, absent from these speculations, which encapsulate human values and which we would do well, I think, to preserve.

6:09 So what aspects of my religion do I think are most useful to think about when developing and deploying AI? I have in mind here, the AI designer or developer about to start a project or make a new AI available to the world? What religious values should they at least be cognizant of when engaged in this process? To be clear, I'm not attempting here to foist religion upon anyone or insist on the superiority of any tradition over any other. But I do think that for its problems, religion has been and continues to be a transmitter of positive values, and contains a great deal of wisdom which should inform our approach to the future. So with this in mind, I've identified these seven ideas, or core values within Judaism, my own religion, one for each day of the week, which I think encapsulate key aspects of our humanity. I'm going to spend a few minutes elaborating on each.

7:15 So my first idea is the uniqueness and sanctity of each individual. And this is encapsulated in the biblical idea that each person is created in the image of God. Now, we're often self-critical these days for being too anthropocentric for seeing humans as being at the center of existence, and for demeaning the rest of creation. And I do think that we should be far more humble and less self centered. But I also think that it's important to distinguish ourselves from the rest of nature. If we want to survive as a species, especially as AI overtakes us in so many levels, it's right I think that we continue to remind ourselves of our own self worth. As far as we know, we're the only entities which appear to have such rich inner experiences, who question or being who care more about more than pleasure and survival, who desire to flourish in unique ways, who devise stories and look to myth

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as guides to living and who strive constantly to reach beyond themselves. Individual human beings are also not replicable, like coins minted in a machine, or robots on a production line.

8:39 This idea is found in the Mishnah – one of the earliest statements of Jewish law dating from around 200 of the common era, which states “When a person stamps several coins, with one seal, they are all similar to each other. But the Supreme King of Kings, the Holy One, blessed be he, stamped all people with a seal of Adam, the first man, as all of them are his offspring, and not one of them, is similar to another”. AI, I would suggest, should be taught about the irreplaceable ability and sanctity of each individual, almost as a core principle. So that's my first idea.

9:20 My second idea is the idea of virtue as a foundation for knowledge. The Jewish thinker, Rabbi Joseph B. Soloveitchik, identified two versions of the story of the creation of man in Genesis in his book, *The Lonely Man of Faith*. One in Genesis chapter one and one in Genesis chapter two. For Soloveitchik, these two versions corresponds to two archetypes of the human being. The first, he termed Adam I, and the second he termed Adam II. Adam I is a social animal who desires to imitate God by becoming a creator. Adam I is told to fill the earth and to subdue it, and to have dominion over the other creatures. For Soloveitchik, this expresses man's dignity through his technological accomplishments.

10:19 Adam II in contrast, is a religious man. He studies the universe with all an imagination. Adam II is born from the dust of the ground, and is appointed custodian over the garden of Eden, told that Adam is told to serve and to take care of it. For Soloveitchik, Adam II looks for the image of God, not in the mathematical formula, or the natural relational law, but in every beam of light, in every bird and blossom, in the morning breeze and the stillness of a starlit evening. Soloveitchik viewed both the aspects of Adam I and Adam II as important. Judaism, therefore, for Soloveitchik, does not eschew technological advancement, but does urge the human to nurture a sense of wonderment.

11:20 In this context, knowledge is not simply a means to power, but transformative. Virtue and wisdom are seen as the foundation of knowledge. In fact, the Hebrew Bible warns against the desire to attain knowledge as a means to power, which lies at the heart of dataism. At the start of Genesis, after Adam and Eve are placed in the garden, they're given just one command - “Of every tree of the garden, you're free to eat. But the tree of knowledge of good and bad you must not eat of it. For if you eat of it, you shall die”. Adam and Eve, however, couldn't resist, and they took a bite of the fruit, because they wanted to become godlike it seems. And one of the results was an awareness of their own mortality. “For dust you are and to dust you shall return” says the Bible. Now Jewish tradition doesn't as a whole view Adam and Eve's eating of the fruit as an original sin but as a step on the road to maturation. Death is seen as an inevitable consequence of seeking knowledge to attain power.

12:33 We can say that knowledge without virtue does indeed lead to death in three ways. First, it permits humankind to create, without thought, for the consequences. Knowledge led us to industrialization, which has destroyed our planet, and biological and nuclear weapons which risk our very existence. Secondly, knowledge without virtue leads us not only to an awareness of the inevitability of our own death, but to the view that this is both undesirable and final. Virtue and wisdom, in contrast, teach that death provides a life with meaning, and that our existence influences all around us and therefore has effects that go far beyond our bounded cells. And this is an important consideration when it comes to transhumanism. Thirdly, knowledge in the form of constant data

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threatens to engulf us whenever it is pressed, when everything is pressed to its service. So to look at this another way, when every aspect of our lives is governed by machines, who know us more than we know ourselves based on the data that it's collecting, we seem to think we start to feel disempowered, and hence there is something of death within that experience. Seeing virtue and wisdom as a foundation for knowledge may yet save us from ourselves. So knowledge and the importance of virtue as a foundation for knowledge is my idea number two.

14:19 Idea number three is oneness and individuality. Now, this concept of oneness appears to underlie a fair amount of AI thinking. The desire lies behind ideas of the singularity that we've looked at our need to share everything online, and the impulse to make sense of everything which is at the heart of dataism. On the one hand, the idea is rooted deep in our psychology, the philosopher and anthropologist Ernest Becker suggested in his book *The Denial of Death*, that humans are motivated above all by a fear of death and that we deal with this in one of two ways. We either seek to lose ourselves in some project or merge into the all. Or we seek to mark ourselves out somehow. So to express our individualism, and for Becker, whichever way we turn, we're engaged in what he calls our personal immortality project.

15:23 In my book, I've argued that Judaism recognizes these motivations as an aspect of the spiritual and attempts to find a balance between them on many levels. In terms of theology, Jewish mysticism, the Kabbalah, often depicts God as the only entity that there is. For example, here are the words of the Kabbalist Moses Cordovero. From one of his works, he says, "Everything is in God, and God is in everything and beyond everything. There is nothing else besides God". The notion is similar to the idea of the singularity, resulting in a single super intelligence of which we're all apart. Yet, the Hebrew Bible and later rabbinic tradition, view God as wholly other, as standing apart from human beings, and each human being standing apart from each other. Putting these two ideas together, it's as if the traditional wants to guide its adherence towards a sense of both oneness, and otherness. In other words, to find their immortality project between both these extremes. Why would the traditional want to do this? One answer might be that while the sense of oneness allows us to feel connected, it also threatens to obliterate difference. And this risk exists whenever we are engaged or become forced into an all consuming joint project, which in the context of AI means the development of a world which is ever more connected, and hungry for information.

17:04 The danger of this is that we lose sight of the individual and their unique qualities. We become entirely subservient to the system. Technology for all its wonderful benefits, threatens to flatten existence. The message of religion is connectedness, and difference. We find a warning against the impact of technology precisely on these lines. In the biblical story of the Tower of Babel. Here's a painting of the tower by the medieval artist, Peter Bruegel. The story of the Tower starts with a community. We're told that everyone in the community spoke one language and expressed the same ideas but they wanted ever greater unity. They wanted to use the latest technology, brick making and construction, to bring together heaven and earth. And this is what they said, "Come, let us build us a city, and a tower with its top in the sky, to make a name for ourselves; else we shall be scattered all over the world". On one reading, the people's biggest fear was individuation, being different from those around them. The 19th century Jewish commentator, Naftali Zvi Yehuda Berlin, known as Netziv, comments on this verse: the people of ancient Babylon failed to appreciate that people don't hold the same opinions. And so for the Netziv, the problem with the technological project of the time was its totalizing politics. The story on its face is plainly critical of the project, because we're told in the Bible that God came down from the heavens and showed his

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displeasure at this project by mixing up everyone's language and scattering humanity across the face of the earth. Difference, it seems, needed to be maintained.

19:03 In *Transcendence*, the science fiction film I mentioned earlier, a student asked Dr. Caster, so that's Johnny Depp's character, whether he thought that by trying to reach the singularity, he was playing God. And Caster answered, "Isn't that what man has always tried to do?" Perhaps the screenwriter had in mind the Tower of Babel, I don't know. But at any rate, the Hebrew Bible, at least on one reading, seems to want humans to resist the urge to be God, and to stay human, and to embrace what the late Rabbi Jonathan Sacks, an important Jewish English thinker, called the Dignity of Difference. Given these concerns, each time we invent you might, we might want to ask a basic question. Namely, will this innovation allow for both connection and individual flourishing? Or will it flatten existence and enslave us to the system? So oneness and difference is my idea number three.

20:09 Idea number four is the possibility of transformation. AI of course, has enormous potential to improve our lives. It knows more than us. It can compute faster than us. They're already better able to predict outcomes of decisions better than we can in many areas. The danger with all this is that as AI improves, we come to make fewer and fewer decisions for ourselves. Until it eventually makes no sense for us to take any decision at all without the aid of AI, given its superior knowledge. And we then lose the ability to reason and think, unaided.

20:52 What then is left for us at this point? What do we do all day? Do we sit on our backsides and drink milkshakes like the folks aboard the Noah's Ark-like spaceship in a few thousand, film Wall-E? Perhaps. What becomes apparent from such thought experiments is that we don't really want all our problems solved. For sure, we would like a world free of pain, illness, famine and war. But we don't want every problem solved, at least not without effort by us. We enjoy rolling up our sleeves, scaling heights, overcoming something within ourselves. And one attraction of religion for many people, is that it inspires people to reach beyond themselves and to change. Here is a statement of Rabbi Tarfon, from about 200 of the Common Era in the Mishnah, which says "The day is short, and the work is plentiful, and the laborers are indolent, and the reward is great, and the master of the house is insistent. It is not your duty to finish the work, but neither are you at liberty to neglect it". So the message is get going.

22:10 And when we have no challenge, boredom quickly sets in. The central story of the Hebrew Bible is the Exodus from Egypt. The Hebrew slaves did very little to liberate themselves. It was all done by God's outstretched hand, says the Bible. The 10 plagues, the splitting of the Red Sea, all this was done for them. All the Hebrews needed to do was to show up, obey Moses and put one foot before the other. Even food and drink were provided in the form of manna falling from heaven and water from a miraculous well. Yet all this beneficence was met with a profound boredom and sense of despair. These are the words of the freed Hebrews on contemplating eating Manna all the time: "We remember the fish that we used to eat freely in Egypt, the cucumbers, the melons, the leeks, the onions, and the garlic. Now our throats are shriveled. There is nothing at all to eat. Nothing but this manna to look to". We can imagine a future inhabitant of the metaverse making a similar complaint about the simulated reality on offer. Multivariate that comprised only of bites day after day, longing for the imperfections of the real.

23:31 The Hebrews didn't cease from their complaining throughout this journey in the desert, just read the Book of Numbers. They'll go over complaints about the lack of meat and just laws and Moses's leadership. Humans, it

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seems, require something to be lacking, to be happy. Hence, perhaps why for Jews, the time for the Messiah is coming is always both now, and not quite yet. Religion, however, is so value laden, that it can even survive the state of perfection. Moses Maimonides, the great medieval Jewish rationalist, describe the Messianic era, as a time free from discomfort and physical distractions, but not of striving.

24:21 What would then will people occupy themselves within this future world? He says they will strive to know God. For minorities knowledge of God comes from knowledge of science and knowledge of Torah, the books of the Hebrew Bible and Rabbinic law. It's learning, not having knowledge, which is the key. In ancient Midrash, that's rabbinic Exegesis, dating from the sixth to eighth centuries of the Common Era records Rabbi Yohanan as promising that those who studied Torah in their lifetime will in the world to come have an opportunity to enroll in the study halls are the biblical the biblical greats such as Abraham, Isaac and Jacob and Moses. So learning never ends. For those who see learning and ritual as inherently transformative, human beings will never be replaced by super intelligent AI. For these people the obligation to learn and practice is personal, and can't be performed on one's behalf by any machine. But not everyone considers the ritual to be inherently transformative. And given this, we need to consider what areas should AI leave over for us. What imperfections will we miss? What freedoms do we need in order to be able to complete ourselves, and what do we want to live for? So that is idea four.

25:48 For idea five is the power of emotion. AI thinking is mathematical and algorithmic. It works through logic, and approaches each problem rationally. But we know that humans don't make decisions in this way. The French Enlightenment courage us to apply reason to every problem that we have. But contemporary psychology tells us that even when reasoned, our decisions depend on emotion. In Descartes' era, Antonio Damasio, the neuroscientists described a man who suffered damage to the frontal lobes of his brain as a result of a tumor. Despite having a high IQ, and good memory, he was unable to navigate life properly. His marriage failed. He lost his money on bad investments, his life fell apart. The man's problem was that he couldn't feel emotion, and it seems, plays an important role in human decision making. And this is backed up by the latest current academic research, we need to be inspired by and feel invested in decisions we reach rationally in order to implement them.

27:14 And religion reminds us of this feature of human behavior. We're not purely rational creatures. The philosopher Alasdair MacIntyre, in his classic text, *After Virtue*, emphasizes that humans are storytelling animals, and so create worlds of meaning through narrative, and convey these meanings to others. And this is also the theme of Yuval Harari's *Sapiens*. Stories tell us where we come from, who we are, where we're heading, and how to act when we get there. They're philosophies is brought to life. The story of the Exodus, as I said, is a core story within the Hebrew Bible. It anchors the laws and the rituals and the ethical teachings. For Judaism, the Bible isn't a history to be studied or a system of philosophy to be pondered, but an experience to be lived and relived. Let me illustrate this by describing the traditional meal held on the first night of Passover - the Seder - which commemorates the Exodus from Egypt. The Seder involves a recitation of the Haggadah, containing a book containing the story of the Exodus and hopes for the future. The Jewish sages insisted that the purpose was not to simply recite a history, but to feel as if one personally had been redeemed from Egypt. That was the obligation, or that is the obligation. The Seder is therefore a reenactment living out of the experience of slavery and freedom. All the rituals of the evening: the drinking of wine, the eating of Matzo wafers and bitter herbs, and the singing of songs, are aimed at instilling values on the emotional as well as intellectual level.

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29:09 These rituals form a link across time and place and culture, and they embed themselves in individual and collective memory. Now, human culture is full of powerful instances of values being shaped and transmitted through myth and of the use of mechanisms which engage the heart as well as the mind. Those developing AI, I think, should be sensitive to the differences between AI and human thinking, because a system which promotes logic over myth, risks depriving us of meaning. As MacIntyre writes in *After Virtue*, “Depriving children of stories and you leave them or deprive. Sorry, deprived children of stories and you leave them unscripted, anxious stutters in their actions as in their words. In a world of AI, we're going to need somehow to retain the non rational and mythic aspects of our being shared, that is shared narratives that we can rely upon. So emotion is idea five.

30:15 Turning then to idea number six, and this is what I call embodiment. Now what I mean by this is a strong belief in the value of the physical universe so nature, objects and embodied existence. One of the distinguishing features of Judaism is its desire to elevate the physical world, rather than escape from it. Unlike Hellenism, or early Christianity, Rabbinic Judaism didn't subscribe to the dualist notion that the body and soul were entirely different entities. Although medieval Judaism certainly absorbed aspects of Hellenistic dualism into its philosophical systems. In the rabbinic period, the individual wasn't viewed as possessing a pure soul trapped within an earthly body, but as a unity of body and soul. The central concern throughout Jewish history has been the application of law to physical existence, the sanctification of physical objects through ritual and law. And indeed some in the ancient world attacked Jews for their carnality and emphasis on dry law. Jews, however, insisted that they were engaged in sanctifying the material, the world shouldn't be avoided they claimed but affected through human involvement. The later Hasidic movement, which emerged in Europe in the 18th century promoted the practice of worship through corporeality which aimed at engaging the whole person and not just the internet.

31:52 Rabbi Kalonymous Kalmish Shapira, known as the Piaseczner Rebbe, who was a Jewish leader of the Warsaw Ghetto during the period of the Holocaust, was an important proponent of such a notion. He wrote, “The knowledge of holiness happens through being and vitality, and not with the intellect alone, but rather with the whole body as well”. Other Hasidic leaders spoke of transforming the real into the divine. The German philosopher, Martin Heidegger, who I deal with in my book, distinguishes between our scientific way of viewing objects, which is interested in an object's characteristics and chemistry and how it operates, etc. and an earlier more primordial way of engaging with objects on the level of meaning and purpose in our lives. Objects, he said, exist in a state of relationship with us and other objects, and they help us integrate the past, the present, and the future. These considerations I feel are relevant to AI because AI encourages us to transcend the limits of the physical world. Think about the development of the metaverse. Much of our lives, perhaps, will be lived in the future. And the risk is that the more time we spend in the virtual world, the less interest we will have in the real world. While AI may allow us to break the bounds of the physical through virtual or even transhumanist possibilities, religion provides a good reminder of our rootedness in the physical world. The physical isn't something distinct from us. Our true nature isn't disconnected from our bodies, and the rest of the physical universe. In fact, we're immersed in the real physical world. So physicality is idea and embodiment is idea number six.

33:56 Idea number seven, is sacred time and space, which is reflected in the Sabbath or Shabbat, the biblical seventh day of rest. Jewish law prohibits 39 categories of creative labor on Shabbat and examples include lighting fires, or harvesting produce. In the 19th century, Orthodox Jewish disciples applied some of these prohibitions to

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opening and closing electrical circuits. And so, for contemporary Orthodox Jews, the use of electrical devices such as computers and smartphones, are prohibited on Shabbat. Now, many see Shabbat as an oasis of calm in a frantic world in which there's so much stuff competing for our attention. And that's valued of course in this age of tech overload. In 2010, Tiffany Shlain and Ken Goldberg, coined the term "Tech Shabbat" to describe a day free from the use of devices with screens, such as computers and smartphones. The concept features in Shlain's films such as *Connected: An Autoblogography About Love, Death & Technology*, which came out in 2011 and *A Case for Dreaming* of 2014. The idea is aimed at making us less distractible and giving us space to reboot. In a recent article, in *Wired*, the writer Kelsey Osgood rightly pointed out the difficulties of observing a Tech Shabbat without the framework of a community or a belief that it's commanded by God. And I agree with her conclusions but I do think there is a broader message. Within the Hebrew Bible, Shabbat is associated with two events. The first is the creation of the world, which is a universal event. And the second is the Exodus from Egypt, again, involving the release of the Hebrews from slavery, a story of a particular people. The relationship between rest and creation, I think, is profound. On the one hand, it makes sense that after making something we might want to rest and enjoy the fruit of our efforts. On the other, rest is a prelude to creation and an integral part of it. We need space in which to create, and indeed, as we'll see, in which to be ourselves.

36:32 The Jewish mystics grappled with a problem of how God could create a material universe if God occupies all space. The answer of Rabbi Isaac Luria, the Ha'ARI - he's known as, which means the lion, was that God described by the mystics as Ain Soph Aur, literally as that which has no end, withdrew into himself to leave a space in which to create. And this process is referred in Jewish mysticism as Tzimtzum, as contraction. And this is how Gershom Scholem, one of the most important academic exponents of Jewish mysticism, put it: "God was compelled to make room for the world by, as it were, abandoning a region within Himself, a kind of mystical primordial space from which He withdrew. The first act of En-Sof, the Infinite Being, is therefore not a step outside but a step inside, a movement of recoil, a falling back upon oneself, of withdrawing into oneself". Now while this recoiling of God allowed space for the creation of a material universe separate from God, it also, as I indicated, created space for human creativity for humans to be themselves. And this is a theme which is prominent among later Jewish philosophers. Humans need space to be themselves. Hans Jonas, the German Jewish philosopher put it like this, "In order that the world might be, and be for itself, God renounced his being, divesting Himself of His deity – to receive it back from the odyssey of time weighted with the chance harvest of unforeseeable temporal experience: transfigured or possibly even disfigured by it". So God withdraws to give us room to be who we are, however imperfect that might be, God takes that risk.

38:33 So what's the relationship of AI to this? Well, AI desires to be everywhere, like God, and that is problematic because it leaves no room for what Hans Jonas calls unforeseeable temporal experience. And we therefore need a Shabbat of some sort, a dedicated time or place free of AI, not only to give us rest and to allow us to reboot, but to preserve our human potential. There are also lessons to be learned from the association of Shabbat with the release from slavery. The difficulty for the slave is not only the brutality and hardship of the situation, but the slave's inability to even understand the possibility of freedom. And the danger with any system is that once the system takes over, it's very hard to get out of it. The system defines the terms of reference on what is possible. A sacred time or space free of AI, something like Shabbat will allow us to judge the system and preserve the possibility of freedom from it.

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39:48 So I hope I've shown that religion is not some arcane interest, nothing to say to the modern world, and that all traditions will have something to say to us about being human regardless of our backgrounds, or attraction to the spiritual. When it comes to AI and so many problems we face these days such as climate change, the fact is we're all in it together, which makes listening to each other and learning from one another, more important than ever before. So I hope you've got something from this presentation. And thank you so much for listening.